

**The Return of Nationalist Geopolitics:  
Liberal Backsliding and Armed Conflict**

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**Abstract**

The post–Cold War decline in violent conflict has been reversed, giving way to rising instability both within and between states. While many attribute this shift to intensified great-power competition, we argue that *nationalist* geopolitics, manifested through conflict driven by grievances reflecting the political exclusion of ethnic groups and their kin, offers an understudied, alternative explanation. We explain how endogenous and exogenous factors weakened the liberal international order in favor of ethnic nationalism in the early 21st century. This erosion of broader liberal norms, particularly what we call liberal backsliding, started undermining inclusive policies that ultimately destabilized the post–Cold War peace. Using newly updated global data on ethnic power relations (1946–2023), we document a reversal of inclusionary trends that began in the early 2010s. These findings challenge power-centric explanations of global instability and highlight how liberal institutional erosion, particularly in the domain of ethnic inclusion, creates fertile ground for identity-based violence. The return of nationalist geopolitics is thus rooted not only in shifting power relations but also in the retreat of institutional safeguards.

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<sup>1</sup> For use on one of the authors' webpages, following [https://direct.mit.edu/journals/pages/authors#author\\_posting](https://direct.mit.edu/journals/pages/authors#author_posting). The published version is available from MIT Press: <https://doi.org/10.1162/ISEC.a.416>.

The world appears to be gripped by a wave of political violence and geopolitical instability that is upending the post–Cold War optimism that expected a steady decline of war.<sup>1</sup> Instead, geopolitics has returned with a vengeance, first with the Arab Spring’s failure to bring peace and democracy to the Middle East, and even more dramatically with Russia’s annexation of Crimea in 2014. In the years that followed these events, conflict both within and between states has escalated, including Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, surging violence in the Middle East since October 2023, and widespread conflict in other parts of the Global South.

What explains this increase in armed conflict in the twenty-first century? Observers such as Walter Russell Mead and John Mearsheimer contend that this resurgence of conflict reflects a revival of great power competition, asserting that the international system is swinging back into its presumed normal mode.<sup>2</sup> In this view, the return of geopolitics features states competing for power in an anarchic world in which liberal institutions are at best ineffective and at worst destabilizing.<sup>3</sup>

Undoubtedly, the struggle for power and resources among great powers has intensified in the early twenty-first century. Yet classical realpolitik only partly explains this trend, as its focus on state leaders driven by materialist motivations narrowly related to state security leaves out other factors that have critically shaped the ongoing wave of violence—namely, state leaders’ ideological commitments, and disruptive non-state actors. While there is an established literature on ethnic civil war that leaves more room for nationalist ideology and non-state actors, it has developed mostly in isolation from scholarship on geopolitics.<sup>4</sup> This article tries to bring together these research streams.

Rather than viewing the current increase in geopolitics merely as a revival of a timeless power struggle among states, we argue that rising nationalist ideology has promoted exclusionary policies that limit ethnic minorities' access to positions in government, especially within the executive branch. This exclusion in turn increases the risk of violent conflict both within and between states. In the early post–Cold War era, liberal and inclusive norms helped suppress such dynamics by encouraging broader political incorporation. With the disappearance of the communist threat, however, the liberal international order (LIO) gradually overextended itself, embracing deregulation and laissez-faire capitalism domestically while encouraging “hyper-globalization” abroad.<sup>5</sup> The resulting inequalities—together with mounting immigration pressures, deindustrialization, and costly geopolitical overreach through protracted wars in the Middle East—fueled a nationalist backlash. This backlash challenges liberal norms both within the West and beyond, contributing to a broader wave of democratic stagnation or even “autocratization.”<sup>6</sup> Yet these developments did more than weaken democratic institutions. They also entrenched a broader politics of ethnic exclusion, as governments increasingly privileged dominant national groups while restricting minorities' political influence.<sup>7</sup> Liberal backsliding therefore entails not only democratic erosion but also a retreat from inclusive governance. As nationalist ideology spreads and exclusion deepens, the likelihood of both civil conflict and interstate violence increases because the institutional barriers that once dampened conflict weaken.

If the initial post–Cold War decline in political violence can be attributed to rising empowerment of previously excluded ethnic groups, the recent surge in geopolitical instability stems from opposite shifts toward increasing ethnic exclusion and enhanced salience of national division as the liberal world order has been weakening. Welcome to the world of what we call

“nationalist geopolitics,” which has come to increasingly dominate world politics in the twenty-first century.

The logic of nationalist geopolitics differs from conventional accounts of geopolitics in important ways. In classic accounts, power differentials determine the system’s stability and the risk of interstate war, whether through traditional balance of power arguments<sup>8</sup> or dynamic hegemonic theories.<sup>9</sup> By contrast, in nationalist geopolitics, discrepancies between states’ borders and ethnic nations motivate conflict both within and between states. We posit that recent conflicts around the world have been—and still are—to a large extent fueled by nationalist leaders expressing grievances about what they perceive as alien rule over themselves or their “transborder kin.”<sup>10</sup> Again, the ethnic Russians’ separatist rebellion against Kiev from 2014 and Russia’s intervention in 2014 and invasion in 2022 fit this pattern.<sup>11</sup>

To support our argument, we document the resurgence of ethnic nationalism and its destabilizing consequences in the latter half of the post–Cold War era (see next section). We first show a marked rise of ethnic nationalism as a governing ideology since the first decade of the 2000s. We then use data from 1946 to 2023 to show that this ideological shift has contributed to growing ethnopolitical exclusion, reversing the inclusive trajectory that characterized the 1990s.<sup>12</sup> Finally, we show that rising ethnic exclusion, which is associated with increasing geopolitical instability, fuels both civil conflict and interstate conflict. Although the resulting increase in violent conflict remains limited so far, the underlying trends are deeply troubling. Since the early 2010s, multiple indicators point toward mounting tensions and recurring outbreaks of violence across several regions, including the former Soviet Union, the Middle East, and beyond. These developments suggest that the relative stability of the 1990s and the first decade of the 2000s may have rested on political conditions that are now eroding. If the spread of

ethnic nationalism and exclusion continues, the world may be entering a new era of nationalist geopolitics characterized by intensifying grievances, growing instability, and a heightened risk of violent conflict both within and between states.

All in all, critics of liberalism are right to caution against the resurgence of great power competition and to target liberal overreach, particularly the interventions in Iraq and Afghanistan. Yet this critique risks obscuring a crucial feature of the early post–Cold War LIO: the pacifying influence of inclusive practices. Our findings point to the importance of defending these inclusive practices against the ethnic nationalist onslaught to avert violent conflict both within and between states. To the extent that the liberal order restrains rising nationalism, nationalist exclusion, and irredentism, preventing liberal backsliding is not merely a matter of defending norms but a practical strategy for a more peaceful world.

### *Debating the Return of Geopolitics*

The Cold War ended on a note of optimism. Famously, Francis Fukuyama celebrated the “end of history” following democracy and capitalism’s victory over communism.<sup>13</sup> Along similar lines, several thinkers heralded the arrival of globalization and the erosion of state borders.<sup>14</sup> In this view, an era of peace and progress would unfold as international cooperation would gradually replace geopolitics and power politics. Ironically, as this period drew to a close, influential statements on the general decline of war appeared.<sup>15</sup>

Yet even before this high point of liberal optimism, more skeptical observers started to spot dark clouds on the horizon. The conservative thinker Robert Kagan warned of “the return of history and the end of dreams.”<sup>16</sup> Responding to an increasingly harsh diplomatic climate and the Russo-Georgian War, he argued in 2008 that the liberal world order under U.S. leadership had

started to erode: “Nationalism and the nation itself, far from being weakened by globalization, have now returned with a vengeance. Ethnic nationalisms continue to bubble up in the Balkans and the former republics of the Soviet Union. But more significant is the return of great power nationalism.”<sup>17</sup> In particular, Kagan forewarned of Russian revanchism reacting to the enlargement of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO). But he also traced the root of the problem to the collapse of the Soviet Union. This historical trauma triggered the Russian quest to regain historical greatness. In Kagan’s prescient words: “It is not hard to imagine the tremors along the Euro-Russian fault line erupting into confrontation. A crisis over Ukraine, which wants to join NATO, could provoke Russian belligerence.”<sup>18</sup>

Confirming Kagan’s fears, the events in Ukraine in 2014 constituted a historical turning point as Russia reacted to the ousting of the Russia-friendly Ukrainian President Viktor Yanukovich by supporting the separatist provinces in the east and by annexing Crimea. This land grab shocked the West, not least because it signified a gross violation of international law that disrupted European geopolitical stability. Responding to this upheaval, Mead warned against a “return of geopolitics.”<sup>19</sup> Arguing along similar lines as Kagan, he criticized liberals for being naive about power after the end of the Cold War: “Westerners should never have expected old-fashioned geopolitics to go away.”<sup>20</sup> Instead of being integrated into the liberal world order, China, Iran, and Russia increasingly challenged U.S. leadership. But Mead stresses almost exclusively classic great power competition rather than ethnic nationalism.

In a monograph offering a theoretical critique of “liberal hegemony,” Mearsheimer singles out both realism and nationalism as fatal stumbling blocks for liberal visions.<sup>21</sup> This criticism comes into particularly clear focus in Mearsheimer’s interpretation of the Russia-Ukraine War, which treats Russia’s invasion as a predictable reaction to NATO’s eastward

expansion in the first decade of the 2000s.<sup>22</sup> Whereas Mearsheimer's theoretical reasoning in this and other cases follows realist principles, he sees nationalism's ideological influences and nationalist backlashes as further undermining the liberal project, mainly by thwarting liberal interventionism.

Some scholars reject these pessimistic assessments. Arguing that Mead's interpretation fundamentally misunderstands the essence of the rules-based world order, G. John Ikenberry offers a more benign interpretation of China's and Russia's intentions, characterizing them as "part-time spoilers" rather than revisionist challengers.<sup>23</sup> But after Donald Trump won the U.S. election in 2016, Ikenberry had to acknowledge that the LIO was indeed in crisis, albeit while still showing signs of resilience.<sup>24</sup>

The debate continues about whether geopolitics has marginalized the liberal world order.<sup>25</sup> Given Trump's reelection in November 2024, however, there is no doubt that liberal norms and institutions, both within and outside the Western world, are in deep trouble. Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022 and the outbreak of widespread conflict in the Middle East appear to vindicate the realist perspective of eroding norms and institutions. To be sure, Mearsheimer interprets these conflicts through a realist critique of liberal foreign policy, arguing that liberal theories underestimate the military, nationalist, and balance of power dynamics that continue to drive international politics.<sup>26</sup>

Yet the debate about the return of geopolitics has been conducted almost entirely without systematic evidence that extends beyond specific prominent cases such as Ukraine. In particular, it remains unclear whether liberal institutions and norms help or undermine peace in this new geopolitical era and what the consequences will be of their decline. Several researchers use statistical data to analyze democratic backsliding, itself affecting a key tenet of the liberal order.

This scholarship shows that global democracy has been stagnating or even receding in recent years, driven in part by eroding democratic norms in several of the world's largest and most influential democracies, such as India and the United States.<sup>27</sup> A smaller set of pioneering studies documents the expanding influence of illiberal actors in international politics more broadly. These works highlight, for example, the growing role of illiberal governments—such as China, Russia, and the Gulf monarchies—within international organizations, as well as the cross-national diffusion of illiberal policies, including restrictions on nongovernmental organizations.<sup>28</sup> But these scholarly efforts say less about the consequences of illiberal backsliding for political violence. Moreover, their narrow focus on democracy ignores the liberal retreat along other dimensions, such as group rights, governmental and territorial power sharing, and engagement by international organizations.<sup>29</sup>

In sum, given the crisis of the rules-based world order, critics of liberalism feel vindicated in their dismissal of liberal practices. Yet their criticism is typically based on specific cases. As we show below, there is strong evidence that the spread of inclusive policies brings peace. But if that is true, it could be that the current surge in political violence stems from the liberal world order's retreat rather than its inherent flaws.

### *The Return of Nationalist Geopolitics*

Given the current surge of armed conflict around the world, the return of geopolitics is an undeniable fact. But what kind of geopolitics? We argue that the type of geopolitics that has now returned is not merely about power struggles among leading states. Instead, we characterize it as *nationalist* geopolitics, wherein state and non-state actors react to violations of nationalism, which we define as a political principle asserting that a nation should possess state power and



ideally unity within one state.<sup>30</sup> Our conceptual approach to nationalism thus differs from Ernest Gellner's classic definition, which requires congruence between the state and the nation.<sup>31</sup> His definition is too restrictive, however, as some nationalist ideologies undershoot the target of congruence by accepting shared power, whereas others overshoot congruence by claiming dominance over other ethnic groups within the same state. We also refer to populism because it overlaps conceptually with nationalism, and because ethnic nationalists often use it to mobilize support for their claims.<sup>32</sup>

Nationalist influences on geopolitics take two main forms. First, while some ethnic nationalists are content to secure at least a share of state power, other nationalists desire their own nation-state or pursue dominance within existing borders. The latter do so by subordinating or excluding non-nationals, who are often ethnic minorities. Second, ethnic nationalists may also strive to unify all members of the nation within a single state, thereby justifying border changes or irredentist claims toward co-ethnics abroad. Whether seeking congruence or dominance, these assertive types of ethnic nationalism oppose ethnic inclusion such as power sharing because they seek to restrict political representation to those whom they deem as members of the nation. This dynamic can also potentially destabilize borders, as nationalist projects seek to redraw boundaries to incorporate or defend excluded co-nationals living under foreign rule.

Nationalism has been a powerful force since the French Revolution, yet its impact has long been tempered by competing geopolitical ideologies—most notably international liberalism, embodied in the LIO that gradually took shape after World War II.<sup>33</sup> The LIO gained further in strength once the Cold War ended (see figure A1 in the online appendix). Enjoying near ideological hegemony following the collapse of communism, the LIO was supported by the overwhelming military power of the United States. In this environment, the LIO successfully

contained ethnic nationalism and mitigated its destabilizing consequences. Domestically, it fostered the adoption of inclusive policies around the world that supported power sharing with ethnic minorities, thereby reducing the risk of civil war; internationally, it blocked irredentist foreign policies, prohibiting international border change by force.<sup>34</sup> International organizations such as the United Nations, as well as the European Union and other regional organizations, strongly supported these norms of inclusion and territorial integrity.<sup>35</sup>

The LIO's suppression of ethnic exclusion and irredentism is well documented in the literature. Liberal international organizations and norms play a major role in the adoption of inclusive practices, such as power sharing, ethnic autonomy, and minority rights.<sup>36</sup> Scholars also show that liberal norms of territorial integrity suppress revisionist challenges.<sup>37</sup>

Evidence from conflict research also supports the final step from exclusive policies to conflict. In an early attempt to evaluate the impact of liberal governance, Ted Robert Gurr detects a decline in ethnic conflict that followed the immediate turmoil after the end of the Cold War.<sup>38</sup> He links this promising development to the growing strength of liberal "accommodation," which features democracy, group rights, and ethnopolitical inclusion, as well as institutional support from international organizations, such as peacekeeping.<sup>39</sup>

By now most researchers believe that ethnic exclusion and inequality fuel rebellion and civil war.<sup>40</sup> Likewise, there is plenty of evidence linking irredentist policies to the outbreak of both interstate war<sup>41</sup> and civil conflict.<sup>42</sup> Although there is no scholarly consensus, most researchers accept that power sharing in multiethnic states promotes peace by building interethnic trust and reducing grievances associated with ethnopolitical dominance.<sup>43</sup> Ultimately, the strength of the LIO led to a powerful downward trend in both civil conflict and interstate conflict that lasted for about two decades into the post-Cold War era.

But all was not well with the liberal paradigm. Already in the 1990s, a radical variant of liberalism gained influence and laid the foundation for a subsequent ethnic nationalist backlash. In contrast to earlier “embedded” forms of liberalism that accepted state intervention to distribute the gains and mitigate the shocks of economic liberalization,<sup>44</sup> this new variant advocated laissez-faire capitalism internally and unfettered globalization externally. The internal development comprised wide-reaching deregulation that destabilized financial markets and contributed to the great financial crisis of 2008. By originating at the core of the liberal financial system, the crisis cast doubt on the viability of the economic principles associated with the LIO.<sup>45</sup> Already before the crisis, increasing socioeconomic inequality<sup>46</sup> and weakening welfare states<sup>47</sup> created room for illiberal politicians to appeal to populism by drawing heavily on ethnic nationalism,<sup>48</sup> while making clever use of social media to sideline mass media journalists.<sup>49</sup> These trends intensified after the crisis.

Along the external dimension, ethnic nationalists targeted the liberal establishment’s enthusiastic promotion of globalization, which enabled waves of mass immigration,<sup>50</sup> fueled free-trade deindustrialization of entire regions,<sup>51</sup> and gradually transferred decision-making from states to international organizations.<sup>52</sup> The liberal establishment also pushed lower- and middle-income countries to deregulate their economies and adopt liberal institutions, in some cases after military interventions, including in Afghanistan and Iraq. In the West, the resulting “forever wars” added to isolationist impulses;<sup>53</sup> in the Global South, they generated a backlash against the LIO and its institutions, which were increasingly portrayed as foreign impositions that lacked due local input.<sup>54</sup>

Amid this backlash, nationalists rose to power in both major powers and rising regional actors. In the United States, Trump’s “America First” platform explicitly attacked globalism,

multiculturalism, and international institutions and portrayed domestic diversity and inclusion initiatives as undermining national cohesion.<sup>55</sup> In India, the Hindu nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party under Narendra Modi came to power in 2014, pursuing a majoritarian project that marginalized Indian Muslims and Christians and sought to redefine India's secular democracy as a Hindu state.<sup>56</sup> In Russia, Vladimir Putin's regime abandoned a civic conception of Russian statehood in favor of an ethnocultural vision centered on the "Russian world," culminating in the annexation of Crimea and the full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022.<sup>57</sup> In China, Xi Jinping adopted a discourse of "national rejuvenation" that fused authoritarian populism and Han-centered nationalism and that legitimized repressive campaigns in Xinjiang and assertive territorial claims in the South China Sea and toward Taiwan.<sup>58</sup>

The nationalist backlash also affected numerous smaller multiethnic states, where the LIO had once promised reconciliation through democratization and liberal peacebuilding. Heralding the emerging crisis of liberal peacebuilding, for example, the Sri Lankan government abandoned the internally mediated peace process with the insurgent Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam in 2006. Instead, it launched a brutal counterinsurgency and, following a military victory that entailed widespread massacres, established an exclusionary regime dominated by a Sinhala nationalist clique.<sup>59</sup> Nationalist resistance increased even in states that followed liberal prescriptions during their peace processes. In Nepal, for instance, conservative Hindu and high-caste actors accused the inclusive 2015 constitution, adopted as part of the peace process initiated in 2006, of being a foreign interference that undermined traditional hierarchies.<sup>60</sup> Similar nationalist dynamics increasingly characterized peacebuilding and state-building in diverse multiethnic states, such as Burundi, Ethiopia, Myanmar, Rwanda, and Sudan. In these places, liberal templates that emphasized inclusion and human rights increasingly ceded ground

to illiberal approaches focused on military control, patronage, and majoritarian dominance.<sup>61</sup>

Together, these shifts reflect a backlash against the LIO by ethnic nationalists who recast inclusion as foreign interference and their ethnic group's political dominance as an assertion of sovereignty.

This surge of populist and ethnonationalist illiberal opposition began to undermine the LIO, especially after Trump's first election. Several major and emerging powers disengaged from liberal norms and institutions and rejected external prescriptions concerning democracy, minority rights, and international cooperation. Russia went further by waging a campaign of disinformation, political interference, cyber operations, and sabotage to weaken liberal democracy in the West and elsewhere.<sup>62</sup>

Taken together, the LIO's internal and external weaknesses triggered an ethnic nationalist reversal that started in the years following the 2008 global financial crisis. Politically powerful ethnic nationalists undermined key pillars of the LIO and its influence over policymaking. Having gained power in major and minor states alike, ethnic nationalists implemented their exclusionary and irredentist agendas, which ultimately fueled the resurgence of both internal and interstate conflict.

Systematic data support these conjectures: A global resurgence of nationalism has taken hold in the latter half of the post–Cold War period (see figure A3 in the online appendix).<sup>63</sup> After declining since the 1980s and throughout the early post–Cold War years, the share of governments subscribing to nationalist ideology has begun to rise again. In both major powers and smaller multiethnic states, the share of governments subscribing to nationalist ideology has increased from 10 percent of states in 2000 to 17 percent in 2023.<sup>64</sup>

Not surprisingly, the rise of nationalist ideology in the later post–Cold War period stems in large part from exclusionary policies. As described above, such policies typically target groups—often ethnic minorities—that are not seen as part of the “nation.”<sup>65</sup>

### *Tracing Inclusion Backsliding*

Having documented the resurgence of ethnic nationalism in the first decade of the 2000s, in this section we examine one of its anticipated consequences in the form of rising ethno-political exclusion. This is the second part of the causal chain introduced in the previous section, which motivated our analysis in the first place (see figures A1 and A2 in the online appendix). We first show trends in exclusionary and irredentist policies to assess whether the recent nationalist turn that we document coincides with a decisive break from inclusion trends and the relative stability of the early post–Cold War period. This descriptive overview prepares the ground for the more sophisticated empirical examination of the exclusion-conflict nexus in the next section.

By centering on ethno-political exclusion from executive power, our analysis goes beyond existing research on how global democracy, itself a cornerstone of the LIO, has eroded.<sup>66</sup> Although democratic backsliding can undermine the democratic peace,<sup>67</sup> focusing only on electoral institutions is too narrow to capture the general decline of inclusive governance caused by rising nationalist influence.<sup>68</sup> In particular, rather than focusing on democratic deficits, nationalist geopolitics highlights ethnic exclusion and division. Hence, inspired by Gurr’s notion of liberal accommodation,<sup>69</sup> we propose a broader conceptualization of *liberal backsliding* that encompasses not only democratic backsliding but also the erosion of ethnic inclusion, group rights, institutional power sharing, and the pacifying role of international organizations. Together, these components formed the normative and institutional core of the LIO. Their

decline not only weakens domestic political cohesion but also heightens the risk of both civil conflict and interstate conflict by removing constraints on exclusionary nationalist policies.

Ethnic inclusion concerns whether ethnic groups are represented in executive power and recognized as legitimate participants in the political community. Ethnopolitical exclusion denotes the opposite condition: groups are denied access to executive power and are therefore governed by elites who rule in the name of another ethnic group. We refer to this condition as alien rule. Although alien rule is not itself a form of nationalism, exclusionary nationalist projects often produce it by restricting political authority to those deemed members of the nation. We treat these developments as a form of liberal backsliding, more specifically *inclusion backsliding*: a decline in ethnic inclusion marked by an increase in exclusion that exposes ethnic groups and their kin to alien rule within their respective countries. With the return of nationalist geopolitics, we expect such reversals to make both civil conflict and irredentist interstate conflict more frequent.

There are good reasons why status reversals resulting in exposure to alien rule at home are particularly conducive to grievances and violent reactions. Psychological mechanisms explain why demoted groups might use violence to attempt to “reverse a reversal.”<sup>70</sup> For instance, social movement theory explains how political activists rely on “injustice frames” to construct grievances about losses inflicted by specific outgroups.<sup>71</sup> Prospect theory, which shows that risk-taking is more prominent in the domain of losses than of gains, can also account for this effect.<sup>72</sup> Previous studies find strong evidence that ethnic groups suffering “status downgrading” are more likely to rebel.<sup>73</sup>

Hence, we expect the global resurgence of nationalism to generate destabilizing consequences. Rising nationalist influence first manifests itself in a broader pattern of liberal

backsliding that includes not only eroding democratic institutions but also increasing ethnic exclusion. In turn, these exclusionary dynamics intensify nationalist geopolitics by fueling conflict both within and between states.

Descriptive statistics may offer at least some clues about the timing of the disruption in the inclusion trend that emerged after the end of the Cold War. To that end, we explore trends in inclusion backsliding at the global level. The sample includes the entire post–World War II period, but our focus is on the early twenty-first century. We first determine whether inclusion backsliding occurred and then assess trends of civil conflict and interstate conflict.

#### FROM DECLINING TO RISING DOMESTIC ETHNIC EXCLUSION

We use the Ethnic Power Relations database, which maps the ethnic composition of governments around the world since World War II,<sup>74</sup> to study the likelihood that an ethnic group will be excluded from executive power within the country where it resides and thus exposed to alien rule. Figure 2 traces this probability. The curve reveals a steadily declining exclusion trend. About 67 percent of all groups were excluded from power at the end of World War II, down to 55 percent by the 2010s. Since 2010, in stark contrast, 65 previously included groups experienced exclusion, bringing the total percentage to 57. More than half of these groups are in sub-Saharan Africa,<sup>75</sup> but some downgrading events also occurred in Asia,<sup>76</sup> Eastern Europe,<sup>77</sup> and even in the United States and the United Kingdom. Although it is too early to confirm whether this trend will persist, the increase has lasted for more than a decade and follows the resurgence of nationalism. This trend certainly stands out in contrast to decades of declining exclusion since World War II.



TRENDS IN IRREDENTIST CONFIGURATIONS. Our analysis in the previous section ignored cross-border ethnic divisions and focused on ethnopolitical exclusion within states as a measure of alien rule. To address this omission, we now turn to irredentist configurations by tracing the trend in state dyads with state-controlling ethnic groups that have excluded kin abroad (see figure 3).<sup>78</sup> Similar to exclusion at the domestic level shown in figure 2, irredentist configurations featuring excluded kin groups fell from 2.3 to 1.7 percent per dyad throughout the post–World War II period. Yet, as with domestic exclusion, the post–Cold War trend stopped declining in about 2010. Again, the probability that a dyad contains excluded kin has increased since 2010. This trend reversal thus contributes to inclusion backsliding.

Since 2010, states in many regions of the world have featured state-controlling groups with transborder excluded kin. In Eastern Europe, for instance, Hungarian minority representatives lost access to Slovakia’s governing coalition after the 2020 elections, when Most–Híd failed to enter parliament and the incumbent Smer-led coalition was voted out of office.<sup>79</sup> This shift to exclusion opened the opportunity for irredentist claims from Hungary. Prime Minister Viktor Orbán has increasingly championed the idea of a “Greater Hungary” that incorporates territories that were lost in the Treaty of Trianon in 1920.<sup>80</sup> Similarly, the Turkish minority in Bulgaria became excluded from government after the 2014 parliamentary elections.<sup>81</sup> Historically, the Bulgarian Communist Party viewed this minority as an irredentist threat, justifying ethnic discrimination and assimilationist policies during the socialist regime of the 1960s.<sup>82</sup> Irredentist and expansionist rhetoric has become more common in Turkey just as it has in Hungary.<sup>83</sup> Sixteen sub-Saharan African states fit into this category as well.<sup>84</sup> Recent potential irredentist cases encompass almost all the states in the Middle East and North Africa, as well as

states in Asia (e.g., China, Indonesia, and Malaysia) and Central Asia (e.g., Afghanistan, Tajikistan, and Uzbekistan).

Although conflicts have not erupted in most of these states, irredentist claims motivated Russia's annexation of Crimea and its support for separatist violence in the Donbass region, particularly after the party representing secessionist ethnic Russians was excluded from executive power.<sup>85</sup> Potential conflict could also arise as groups with excluded ethnic kin abroad become politically dominant in their own countries. For example, Pashtuns in Afghanistan, who rose to power after the Taliban takeover, have historically backed their kin's secessionist efforts in Pakistan.<sup>86</sup>

In sum, we find a pronounced reversal of the post–Cold War trend toward greater ethnic inclusion: after ethnic nationalism resurged in the first decade of the 2000s, exclusion began to rise again around 2010. In particular, we observe that the proportion of ethnic groups around the world that are excluded from executive power increased and that the number of state dyads with excluded kin in other states has also increased. For the first time in decades, both the incidence of irredentist configurations and the number of excluded groups show a sustained increase, signaling a shift toward a more exclusionary and conflict-prone international order. Our descriptive analysis thus offers support for our argument that a rise in exclusion and irredentism followed an earlier resurgence of nationalism.

### *Was There a Reversal in Conflict Trends?*

Is it possible to detect corresponding trends in civil conflict and interstate conflict, the final step of our causal sequence?<sup>87</sup> It takes time for exclusive and irredentist shocks to bring about actual conflict behavior. As an initial assessment, figure 4 traces the trend in probability of ethnic civil conflicts per group.<sup>88</sup>

As Gurr first detected in 2000, civil conflict decreased in the post–Cold War period beginning in the mid-1990s.<sup>89</sup> We complement this picture with conflict data that span from 1946 to 2023.<sup>90</sup> These data suggest that conflict trends are potentially reversing, although the shift occurs later and is less clear than the turning point in exclusion. Indeed, the post–Cold War decline in violent conflict plateaued in the 2010s and the curve now appears to be turning upward in figure 4. Ethnic civil conflicts that have emerged or escalated in the last two decades include the separatist conflict in the Donbass region of Ukraine, the Tigray conflict in Ethiopia, secessionism by ethnic Armenians in Azerbaijan, and resurgent conflict between the Sudan People’s Liberation Movement and the government.<sup>91</sup>

Does the increase in ethnopolitical exclusion and alien rule account for this uptick in ethnic conflict? We address this question more systematically in the next section, but here we note that several recent conflicts erupted following exclusionary shifts. First, the separatist violence in the Donbass region of Ukraine, inhabited by a large ethnic Russian population, erupted not long after the pro-Russian Party of Regions lost power in the aftermath of the 2014 Euromaidan revolution.<sup>92</sup> Likewise, the Taliban’s takeover of the government in Afghanistan in August 2021 led to an immediate armed response by ethnic Hazara, Tajiks, and Uzbeks, who formed the National Resistance Front after their ouster from government.<sup>93</sup> In Ethiopia, conflict erupted in the Tigray region as the Tigrayan People’s Liberation Front became gradually excluded from executive power after 2018.

Having found suggestive patterns that civil conflict has recently increased, we now turn to interstate conflict. As Myron Weiner argues,<sup>94</sup> irredentist configurations are associated with a higher risk of not only civil<sup>95</sup> but also interstate conflict.<sup>96</sup> Although some interstate conflicts are non-ethnic, we expect that many are related to irredentism. Because ongoing interstate conflicts

are not only less frequent since the end of World War II but also less distinguishable from internal conflicts,<sup>97</sup> we also consider internationalized civil wars that feature foreign military support for a party in a civil war.<sup>98</sup> Russia's "little green men"—that is, the soldiers without insignia who invaded Crimea<sup>99</sup>—illustrate how states attempt to conceal their involvement in illegal activities abroad.<sup>100</sup>

Using a measure that combines such indirect or covert involvement in internationalized internal conflict, as well as direct involvement through interstate conflict, we study the relevant trends in the probability that a state dyad experiences such a process. This analysis reveals a powerful decreasing trend since the 1980s. But again, a global resurgence of nationalism interrupted this trend in the first decade of the 2000s. Indeed, as figure A7 in the online appendix shows, interstate conflicts and internationalized conflicts increased in the subsequent period, as did interstate conflicts alone. Together, interstate and internationalized civil conflicts from this last wave include: Russia's 2014 annexation of Crimea and its involvement in the separatist violence in the Donbass region, as well as its full-scale invasion in 2022; Azerbaijan's offensives in Nagorno-Karabakh; and Rwanda's support for the March 23 Movement (M23) since its resurgence in 2021 in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo, where cross-border ethnic ties and claims of protecting co-ethnics form an important part of the justification for intervention.

In sum, we identify some tentative signs that nationalist geopolitics is resurging. Indeed, our descriptive data analysis shows that nationalism's resurgence in the first decade of the 2000s may be linked to an upsurge of ethnic exclusion that was followed by a rise in civil conflict. It is also plausible that the simultaneous rise in interstate conflict responds to the exclusion of ethnic kin.

## *Revisiting the Exclusion-Conflict Nexus*

To connect the dots between the macro trends in exclusion and political violence more systematically, this section examines whether an increased prevalence of excluded ethnic groups and their kin can indeed be more directly linked with rising conflict in the latter half of the post–Cold War period. We first consider internal conflict dynamics before turning to violent interstate processes. Both analyses draw on global evidence and use suitable statistical methods to test our expectations. In addition, we complement quantitative analyses with qualitative probes of key cases to illustrate and substantiate the broader patterns. These include the well-known case of Ukraine—including both the Donbass civil war and Russia’s 2022 invasion—as well as a less prominent case that did not shape our initial theorizing: minority rebellions against Taliban rule in Afghanistan.

### ANALYZING THE EFFECT OF ETHNOPOLITICAL EXCLUSION ON CIVIL CONFLICT

As discussed previously, there is substantial evidence supporting the link between ethnopolitical exclusion and the outbreak of civil conflict. A first wave of research finds a strong connection that operates mostly through grievances and resentment. Though insightful, these studies are too dated to trace recent trends in inclusion backsliding.<sup>101</sup>

Focusing on changes over time within ethnic groups around the world, we apply a staggered difference-in-differences estimation to a recently updated version of the exclusion and conflict data that spans from 1946 to 2023.<sup>102</sup> This approach isolates how changes in political status (the treatment) affect the likelihood of civil conflict by comparing each group’s conflict incidence before and after such shifts, while controlling for confounding influences. The design assumes that absent a change in political status, groups would have followed similar conflict

trends as those that did not experience such a change. Importantly, this assumption that treated and comparison units moved in parallel before treatment can be empirically verified through event studies—stable and nonsystematic pre-treatment coefficients indicate that the untreated counterfactual trend is credible.<sup>103</sup>

Substantively, we examine whether groups are more likely to experience conflict after losing access to power rather than before.<sup>104</sup> Our research design allows us to compare groups that did and did not have to leave government. The findings indicate a 5-percentage-point increase in the annual probability of an ethnic group rebelling (see figure A11 in the online appendix). This is a considerable increase—roughly doubling the risk of conflict—given that the base rate is 2–6 percent.

A series of further analyses probe the mechanisms linking ethnopolitical exclusion to conflict (see table A2 in the online appendix). These results show that exclusion's effects are concentrated in non-democracies, among groups advancing territorial claims, and under governments subscribing to nationalist ideology. These patterns are consistent with the pathways implied by our theoretical argument. Together, these results indicate that exclusion is most likely to produce rebellion when political environments amplify nationalist grievances and when institutional constraints on conflict are weaker.

Building on these quantitative results, we examine two recent cases that illustrate this pattern: the Donbass conflict in Ukraine, and armed resistance to the Taliban takeover in Afghanistan. In both instances, violent mobilization occurred after key ethnic groups were excluded from power.

**UKRAINE AND SEPARATIST VIOLENCE IN THE DONBASS.** A central case that exemplifies the logic of nationalist geopolitics is the civil conflict in eastern Ukraine that erupted

in 2014, preceding Russia's full-scale invasion in 2022. We argue that when formerly included groups lose political access, exclusion generates grievances and thereby heightens the risk of rebellion. In Ukraine, long-standing regional divides erupted into conflict after the ousting of the Donbass-based Party of Regions and President Viktor Yanukovich in early 2014 marginalized ethnic Russian and pro-Russian politicians. Although the conflict later became internationalized through Russian support for separatist forces, it originated in a domestic political realignment that altered the distribution of executive power and left key segments of the population newly excluded from government.

Understanding this conflict's history sheds light on why this exclusion proved so destabilizing. While Ukrainian nationalism has a long history, a foundational statement of modern Ukrainian historiography is Mykhailo Hrushevsky's 1903 essay, published in 1904, which rejected the traditional Russian imperial historical schema and portrayed Ukraine-Rus' as a distinct historical subject whose origins traced back to Kyivan Rus'.<sup>105</sup> This vision of a distinct national identity endured through periods of foreign domination and gained renewed political salience after independence in 1991.<sup>106</sup> Aspirations for a democratic and European-oriented Ukraine, rooted in this revived nationalism, fueled the 2004 protests following Yanukovich's disputed election, culminating in the Orange Revolution and a rerun of the vote. The episode exposed a widening divide between a westward-looking Ukrainian identity and a more Russia-oriented vision concentrated in the east. As Moscow's preferred candidate and a native of Donbass, Yanukovich promoted closer ties with Russia, designated Russian as a state language, and supported dual citizenship.<sup>107</sup> These policies sharply diverged from those of previous governments, which emphasized Ukrainian identity and highlighted its differences with Russia,<sup>108</sup> thereby reinforcing regional divides that would later underpin the outbreak of conflict.

Russia's influence over Ukraine declined further after Yanukovych's defeat in the election rerun, especially as the winner, Viktor Yushchenko, promoted "nationalizing" policies. Most notably, such policies included recognizing Soviet-inflicted famines such as the 1932–1933 Holodomor as a genocide and granting the "Hero of Ukraine" award to World War II-era nationalist Stepan Bandera, whom many in eastern Ukraine view as a traitor.<sup>109</sup> These measures deepened east-west divisions within Ukraine and intensified Russia's concerns about its declining influence, particularly in Crimea, where Moscow portrayed the local Slavic population as threatened by "Tatar Wahabis."<sup>110</sup> Yet divisions within the pro-Western "Orange" camp allowed Yanukovych to return to power in 2010, after which he reversed many of Yushchenko's initiatives and reoriented Ukraine toward Russia.<sup>111</sup> His increasingly authoritarian rule and pervasive corruption, however, set the stage for his eventual ousting.<sup>112</sup>

In late 2013, Yanukovych abandoned plans for closer integration with the European Union and instead moved toward Ukraine's participation in the Russia-led Eurasian Economic Union, after Moscow offered substantial financial assistance.<sup>113</sup> This decision contradicted the earlier declarations of the Party of Regions that it intended to integrate Ukraine into Europe.<sup>114</sup> The reversal triggered the Euromaidan movement, which began as student-led demonstrations for European integration but quickly evolved into a broader protest against Yanukovych's increasingly repressive and authoritarian rule.<sup>115</sup> When protesters rejected a deal reached among Yanukovych's regime, top diplomats, and opposition leaders, the president fled Ukraine on February 21, 2014, and was subsequently removed from power by Parliament.<sup>116</sup>

Central to our argument, Yanukovych's ousting marked a political downgrading from national executive power of the Donbass-based Party of Regions and its ethnic Russian supporters in eastern Ukraine and Crimea.<sup>117</sup> It also meant that Moscow's influence in Ukraine



became more tenuous.<sup>118</sup> Soon protests erupted in eastern and southern Ukraine,<sup>119</sup> and many members of the previous government and the security forces in Crimea defected to the Russian state. These defections facilitated the annexation in the following months, as many of the officers from the “Berkut” riot police that helped repress the protests were originally from Donbass and Crimea. As their resentment grew, they became core members of separatist armed groups.<sup>120</sup>

To justify its intervention, Russia portrayed right-wing groups’ limited involvement in the Euromaidan revolution as evidence that the Russian-speaking population faced imminent persecution.<sup>121</sup> On February 23, it ordered the takeover of Crimea under the pretext of protecting these threatened co-ethnics. To facilitate this intervention, Russia deployed its “little green men” in both Crimea and the Donbass.<sup>122</sup> Crimea holds a special place in Russia’s nationalist ideology, as the city of Sevastopol is tied to myths of martial glory.<sup>123</sup> Yet most justifications for treating Crimea as part of Russia emphasized the region’s ethnic composition, portraying the majority ethnic Russian population as evidence of rightful ownership. In short, Moscow’s drive to reclaim Crimea following Ukrainian independence in 1991 primarily stemmed from concerns that centered on identity rather than on strategy or NATO.<sup>124</sup>

The conflict soon spread to Donbass, home to Ukraine’s second-largest Russian-speaking population (after Crimea).<sup>125</sup> The Party of Regions, with help from the Russian intervention, hoped to use anti-Euromaidan protests to advance its project of a “New Russia” (*Novorossiia*).<sup>126</sup> As they had done in Crimea, Russian volunteers with ties to the Russian government moved to the Donbass to back pro-Russian activists.<sup>127</sup> Many were motivated by the idea of defending members of the *Russkiy Mir*, or the “Russian World”—a concept that Russian President Vladimir Putin, among others, promoted to reclaim Czarist/Soviet imperialist power on behalf of all Russian speakers conceived of as a single nation.<sup>128</sup> The volunteers drew on Russian

media narratives alleging Ukrainian atrocities to justify their intervention; some also sought to displace Ukrainians inhabiting the region.<sup>129</sup> These narratives framed Russian speakers as co-ethnics in need of protection, particularly after they had been excluded from government. In April 2014—after Igor Girkin, a Russian citizen, led a commando to seize Sloviansk in the Donetsk province—the situation escalated to a full-blown separatist conflict. Russian forces, denying official involvement, subsequently intervened to support the insurgents.<sup>130</sup>

To summarize, the Ukrainian case illustrates our broader causal logic that ethnic nationalism and increased exclusive practices can lead to conflict: The ouster of the pro-Russian government motivated both domestic rebellion and cross-border intervention by the Russian kin state. This internationalized, ethnonationalist civil war further escalated as Russia launched its 2022 full-scale invasion of Ukraine.<sup>131</sup>

AFGHANISTAN AND THE RETURN OF PASHTUN DOMINANCE. When the Taliban took over Afghanistan in 2021, the multiethnic power-sharing arrangements that had characterized the Islamic republic abruptly ended. Once again, political authority was concentrated in the hands of a single group, the Pashtuns.<sup>132</sup> This exclusionary shift sharply reduced Hazara, Tajik, and Uzbek representation in the executive and security apparatus, effectively excluding these groups from meaningful decision-making in the new emirate. In direct response to this reversal, leading figures from these communities formed the National Resistance Front (NRF)—a rebel organization comprised mainly of ethnic Tajiks but also Hazaras and Uzbeks—to coordinate anti-Taliban resistance.<sup>133</sup> Led by former political and military elites of the Islamic Republic of Afghanistan, the NRF emerged immediately after the fall of Kabul and mobilized in the Panjshir Valley and neighboring districts. Although initially dismissed as a minor challenge to Taliban control,<sup>134</sup> the NRF has maintained an armed presence

and has expanded its operations beyond its original strongholds in the northeast to additional provinces, including parts of eastern Afghanistan and Kabul.<sup>135</sup>

Conflict between the Pashtuns and various other groups has a long history in Afghanistan. As the country's largest ethnic group, the Pashtuns dominated Afghan politics for centuries. This dominance generated lasting grievances among Hazara, Tajiks, and Uzbeks. The Marxist-Leninist, Soviet-backed People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA) disrupted this long-standing hierarchy when it took power in 1978. The PDPA's radical land, family, and education reforms provoked widespread uprisings in rural Pashtun areas, giving rise to the mujahideen insurgency. With Soviet backing, members from minority groups that opposed the Pashtuns, especially Hazara, Tajiks, and Uzbeks, took government positions.<sup>136</sup>

Multiethnic inclusion began to unravel in 1986 when political authority shifted back toward Pashtun networks as Muhammad Najibullah, a Pashtun, became PDPA leader and president. As the Soviet Army withdrew, factional struggles increasingly followed ethnic rather than ideological lines. In 1992, a coalition of Hazara, Tajik, and Uzbek forces overthrew Najibullah's government, producing a power vacuum and civil war. The conflict that followed reflected efforts these minorities' efforts to end long-standing Pashtun dominance and to restore regional autonomy.<sup>137</sup>

The Taliban emerged from Pashtun mujahideen factions resisting both the communist regime and rival warlords, drawing heavily on Pashtun refugees and madrassa networks in Pakistan.<sup>138</sup> After the Taliban seized most of the country and established a radical Islamist regime in 1996, other groups accused the movement of "narrow ethnic chauvinism,"<sup>139</sup> while resistance persisted in predominantly Hazara, Tajik, and Uzbek regions.<sup>140</sup> Following the U.S.-led intervention to oust the Taliban in 2001, successive governments under Hamid Karzai and

Ashraf Ghani struggled to bridge ethnic divides. Karzai's centralizing policies threatened non-Pashtun autonomy and fueled fears that he would align with pro-Taliban Pashtun constituencies at the expense of minorities.<sup>141</sup> Although Ghani maintained a formally multiethnic elite coalition, his government failed to address grievances among deprived rural Pashtuns, a weakness that facilitated the Taliban's resurgence.<sup>142</sup>

The Taliban's return to power in 2021 again consolidated Pashtun dominance. Scholars debate whether the movement represents a form of Pashtun nationalism or a purely Islamist project.<sup>143</sup> The Taliban have a history of targeting Pashtun nationalist rivals,<sup>144</sup> and recent crackdowns on certain Pashtun cultural practices indicate an effort to suppress competing identity claims.<sup>145</sup> At the same time, the leadership and rank and file remain overwhelmingly Pashtun, and their rhetoric frequently invokes Pashtun cultural and nationalist symbols.<sup>146</sup> In practice, Taliban insiders dominate the new emirate, and the Hazara, Tajiks, and Uzbeks have only token representation in the cabinet, effectively downgrading the Hazara, Tajiks, and Uzbeks and excluding these groups from executive power.<sup>147</sup> In the months following the Taliban takeover, leaders and communities in Hazara-, Tajik-, and Uzbek-majority areas voiced opposition to their lost representation and demanded a more inclusive government.<sup>148</sup> These grievances became a key mobilizing resource for the NRF.

The Taliban's takeover has reignited cross-border tensions with Pakistan, as Pashtuns live on both sides of the Durand Line, the colonial-era border separating Afghanistan and Pakistan.<sup>149</sup> Islamabad has historically supported the Afghan Taliban for strategic reasons,<sup>150</sup> yet relations have deteriorated since 2021 as the Pakistani Taliban (Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan) has intensified its insurgency against the Pakistani state. Pakistani officials accuse the Afghan Taliban of tolerating Pakistani Taliban sanctuaries on Afghan territory and, at times, of offering

more active forms of support. These dynamics contribute to repeated border clashes and Pakistani airstrikes against Afghanistan and illustrate how Pashtun-centered political realignments can activate long-standing kinship-based disputes.<sup>151</sup>

Taken together, the Afghanistan case exemplifies our core argument: Exclusionary regime change that downgrades formerly included ethnic groups can trigger rapid ethnonationalist mobilization. The formation and expansion of the NRF following the Taliban takeover is a clear instance of this mechanism.

## ANALYZING THE EFFECT OF EXCLUDED KIN ON EXTERNAL CONFLICTS

The previous section established a strong link between ethnopolitical exclusion and civil conflict. As already evident from our descriptions of the Ukrainian and Afghan cases, however, conflict frequently transcends national boundaries. Therefore, we consider whether homeland states are likely to attack host states that exclude their transborder kin groups. Our unit of analysis is state dyads, and we use a measure of conflict that includes both direct armed conflicts between the two states and instances when one state intervenes militarily and sends troops to fight in the other state.

Again, we rely on a research design that allows us to compare those states whose kin groups were demoted to those that did not have any excluded kin. Those that did exhibited about a 1-percentage-point increase in the probability of interstate and internationalized conflict per state dyad. This 1-percentage-point increase in the probability of interstate and internationalized conflict per state dyad represents a 17-to-33-fold elevation of the conflict risk, given that the dyadic base rate is 0.03–0.06 percent.<sup>152</sup>

Next, we revisit the case of Ukraine, this time focusing on Russia's full-scale invasion in 2022, whose nationalist roots are often debated.<sup>153</sup>

THE RUSSIA-UKRAINE WAR. A previously discussed, before escalating to full-scale war in 2022, Russia's annexation of Crimea in 2014 and its intervention in the separatist conflict in the Donbass region followed the (self-)exclusion of ethnic Russian representatives from the Ukrainian government. Moscow framed its efforts to annex Crimea and support the conflict in the Donbass as protecting excluded Russian speakers in these regions. We argue that our theory linking excluded kin to increased conflict extends to Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

Some scholars interpret both the annexation of Crimea and the full-scale invasion in 2022 as defensive reactions to NATO enlargement.<sup>154</sup> But Russia draws on irredentist claims to justify the war, directly invoking the protection of kin excluded outside Russia's borders.<sup>155</sup> Indeed, Putin has referred to Ukraine as the artificial product of Vladimir Lenin's division of Russia in the 1920s, arguing that it has no right to exist.<sup>156</sup> As Angela Stent explains, Putin's grievance-laden discourse follows an explicitly irredentist logic: "When Putin described the Soviet collapse as a 'great geopolitical catastrophe of the twentieth century,' he was lamenting the fact that 25 million Russians found themselves outside of Russia, and he particularly criticized the fact that 12 million Russians found themselves in the new Ukrainian state. As he wrote in a 5,000-word treatise published [in the] summer [of 2021] and titled 'On the Historical Unity of Russians and Ukrainians,' in 1991, 'people found themselves abroad overnight, taken away, this time indeed, from their historical motherland.'"<sup>157</sup>

Thus, Russia's leadership justified its intervention in Ukraine as a defense of co-nationals allegedly facing discrimination.<sup>158</sup> In doing so, it portrayed its violent policies as an attempt to unify a divided Russian nation. This framing reflected the "ethnification of Russian nationalism,"

as Russian official discourse increasingly defined the nation as encompassing not only Russia's citizens but also Russian speakers beyond Russia's borders.<sup>159</sup> In fact, the requirement that Russian soldiers invading Ukraine carry Putin's treatise in their pockets further underscores the irredentist motivations behind the conflict.<sup>160</sup>

Russia's territorial ambitions and aggressive behavior toward Ukraine have deep historical roots, preceding both Putin's term in office and Ukraine's attempts to join NATO. While Ukraine was allowed a certain degree of autonomy in the Soviet Union under Lenin, Joseph Stalin introduced Russification policies to counteract what he saw as an anti-Soviet threat.<sup>161</sup> After the collapse of the Soviet Union, Russian nationalists portrayed parts of Ukraine, especially Crimea and the Donbass, as extensions of Russia. In fact, a frequent claim was that Belarus, Russia, and Ukraine should form a single new state, or that Ukraine should change its borders to align with those of the Ukrainian ethnic group, leaving Crimea and eastern/southern Ukraine to Russia. These views were especially prevalent among the nationalist right and communists.<sup>162</sup> Their ideology ultimately prevailed as Boris Yeltsin, the first post-Soviet Russian president, failed to formulate a vision of Russian nationalism that abandoned its imperial aspirations.<sup>163</sup> Russia formally recognized Ukraine's territorial boundaries in 1997. But doing so did little to stem rising Soviet nostalgia in Russia, where economic stagnation and unemployment following liberalization had eroded public confidence in the post-Soviet order.<sup>164</sup>

As Putin rose to power and dismantled Russia's democratic institutions, he made imperial restoration a central pillar of his regime, and his policies increasingly aligned with the nationalist right. After the annexation of Crimea, the Ukrainian government tried to de-escalate, introducing reforms to curb corruption and promote a more inclusive national identity. The election of Volodymyr Zelensky, a Russian speaker from southern Ukraine who initially enjoyed some

popularity in Russia, reflects this effort.<sup>165</sup> Nevertheless, the nationalist ideology of Putin's regime, which denied Ukraine's distinct nationhood and sought to unite all ethnic Russians under Moscow's rule, rendered peace unattainable.

We now turn from estimating the exclusion-conflict relationship to assessing its aggregate implications. Section A9 of the online appendix presents a counterfactual analysis showing what conflict rates would have looked like had the post-Cold War declines in exclusion and irredentism continued through 2023. Under that scenario, the civil conflict rate would have remained close to 2 percent per group-year instead of rising to nearly 4 percent. In other words, the probability of civil conflict in 2023 was about double what would have been expected under the earlier trajectory toward greater inclusion. The pattern is similar for interstate conflict. If the earlier decline in irredentism had persisted, the likelihood of external conflict would have been virtually zero rather than the 0.02 percent per state dyad. In absolute terms, the observed rise in exclusion and irredentism is associated with roughly fourteen additional ethnic groups involved in civil conflict per year and five additional state dyads involved in interstate or internationalized conflict per year, relative to the counterfactual trajectory of continued inclusion. These shifts are troubling. Conflict risks that had been steadily declining for decades have begun to move in the opposite direction, suggesting that the stabilizing trends of the early post-Cold War era are eroding and may continue to deteriorate.

The evidence presented in this section confirms that ethnopolitical exclusion and the presence of excluded transborder kin are closely linked to violent conflict both within and between states. When governments embrace nationalist politics and exclude ethnic groups from political power, the risk of rebellion rises sharply among those who suffer status downgrading as a result of ethnopolitical exclusion. Similar dynamics operate across borders. Groups with



politically mobilized kin in neighboring states are more likely to become involved in interstate or internationalized conflict, as nationalist leaders invoke claims of protection, solidarity, or territorial revision. Moreover, our analysis shows that the relationship between exclusion and conflict has grown stronger in recent years. As ethnic nationalism becomes more politically influential and exclusionary governance spreads, the institutional restraints that once dampened these dynamics appear to be weakening, increasing the potential for renewed instability.

## *Conclusion*

In this article, we have analyzed a broad set of destabilizing developments that are commonly described as the return of geopolitics. Rather than interpreting these developments primarily as a revival of timeless power competition among states, we argue that they reflect the return of what we call nationalist geopolitics. At the center of this dynamic lies a causal sequence in which the resurgence of ethnic nationalism encourages exclusionary political practices that marginalize minority groups and privilege dominant national communities. These exclusionary policies in turn generate grievances, mobilization, and cross-border claims that increase the risk of violent conflict both within and between states.

In this sense, the recent rise in armed conflict is not simply the product of shifting power balances. It is also the result of political struggles over national belonging and political inclusion. As governments increasingly define the state as the political vehicle of a dominant ethnic nation, previously incorporated groups face renewed exclusion, and nationalist leaders justify intervention or territorial claims on behalf of co-ethnics beyond state borders. The resulting combination of domestic exclusion and transborder nationalist claims creates conditions that are historically associated with heightened instability.

From this perspective, the liberal, post–Cold War interlude of relative peace and stability appears increasingly exceptional. The world that preceded it cannot be reduced to textbook *realpolitik* dominated solely by states. Rather, until 1989, international politics emerged from the interaction between classic power politics and the forces of nineteenth-century nationalism, with both states and nationalist movements acting as central protagonists in conflict processes.

We do not deny the reality of great power competition, which is clearly alive and well in the contemporary world, especially in the United States’ efforts to balance against Chinese ascendance and the seeming return of spheres of influence. But interpreting the current increase in armed conflict as interactions between calculating, resource-grabbing states misses the potentially even more important nationalist underpinnings of conflict, as illustrated by the Russia-Ukraine War, the Palestinian rebellion in Israel and its occupied territories, as well as a possible Chinese invasion of Taiwan.

We draw several theoretical lessons from our study. First, nationalist geopolitics challenges conventional conceptions of power politics by emphasizing ideological and identity-driven preferences that often override material interests. Fully aware of nationalism’s importance, critics of liberalism correctly argue that it can reinforce state strength by mobilizing the country’s population.<sup>166</sup> In this view, nationalism is an obstacle to liberal efforts to export democracy because it triggers nationalist separatism.<sup>167</sup> At the same time, these scholars typically fail to realize that nationalist politics can also disrupt the balance of power, especially by changing borders and transforming states.<sup>168</sup>

Furthermore, realists tend to overemphasize identity-blind, power-balancing considerations in explaining key actors’ agendas, but more often such actors are motivated by a desire to counter alien rule and division.<sup>169</sup> Indeed, evidence for Putin’s motives for intervening

in Ukraine provides little support for Mearsheimer's claim that Russia was responding to NATO's eastward expansion.<sup>170</sup> Putin expresses his motives unambiguously in his essays about Russian history, in which he bemoans the Soviet Union's collapse while denying Ukraine's right to exist as a state or a people.<sup>171</sup>

In the Middle East, nationalist geopolitics suggests that lasting peace is unobtainable without a compromise that satisfies the nationalist aspirations of both Israelis and Palestinians. It is difficult to see any alternative to the two-state solution, however improbable it seems at the time of writing.

A failure to see that such security challenges hinge on violations of the nationality principle is bound to cause nasty surprises. Such violations include the failure to anticipate the collapse of the Soviet Union, Putin's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, and Hamas's attack on southern Israel in October 2023.<sup>172</sup> To be better prepared for such events, realist theory needs to be amended to integrate nationalist politics into its core ontology. This amendment should include treating ethnic nations as actors in their own right rather than viewing nationalism as a booster of state power.<sup>173</sup>

Furthermore, attempts to blame liberalism for the current world disorder get that diagnosis at least partly wrong. Liberal interventionism can be counterproductive and deserves its share of blame for triggering illiberal backlash, especially when pursued through military force. Yet we find strong evidence that when states introduced inclusive practices historically associated with the LIO—including political representation for ethnic minorities, group rights, and power-sharing arrangements—both internal and external conflicts decreased. We also document that as these pacifying practices have declined globally since about 2010, both

domestic and interstate conflict in subsequent years have surged. If anything, there are more conflicts today not because there is too much liberalism, but because there is too little of it.

What is needed then is to revive John Ruggie's "embedded liberalism."<sup>174</sup> By ameliorating inequality-related grievances and retaining sufficient financial regulation, liberalism can be made more robust while reducing the risk of illiberal backlashes. In particular, globalization needs to be carefully managed to better integrate migrants and to avoid sudden surges in immigration and deindustrialization of entire regions.<sup>175</sup> As Immanuel Kant observes, liberal democratic states must bind themselves together and establish shared institutions and norms to protect themselves from authoritarian threats, while avoiding prolonged proxy conflicts.<sup>176</sup>

In recent years, researchers have traced the retreat of democracy, a trend that is in itself important but is also relevant to conflict. Yet democratic backsliding affects merely one dimension of the liberal world order. Given the close relationship between nationalism and liberal backsliding, it is imperative to broaden the analytical focus to encompass liberal backsliding more generally, while recognizing ethno-political inclusion as one of its most important conflict-dampening components. Our findings confirm that shifts to ethnic exclusion are closely linked to increases in civil conflict. Similarly, the emergence of excluded transborder ethnic kin raises the risk of external conflicts. In fact, to our knowledge, this is the first systematic study of the violent repercussions of inclusion backsliding. Given data limitations, our study follows the trends only until 2023. But events in the past three years offer little hope that inclusive practices have stopped eroding.

As more and more ethnic groups become marginalized and cut off from their homelands, the risk of destabilization and mass violence within and between states increases. If extremist

right-wing parties continue to advance in elections around the world, democratic governance and other aspects of the liberal world order could enter terminal decline. Together with Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022 and the possibility of future violence in the Middle East, across the Taiwan Strait, and in parts of the Global South, these developments render nationalist geopolitics ever more salient.

Although the LIO stands in inherent tension with the sovereignty of territorial states,<sup>177</sup> this study demonstrates that inclusive liberal institutions and norms have played a decisive role in fostering the enduring pacific trend that followed the end of the Cold War. Their diminishment in the early twenty-first century accounts for much of the geopolitical turbulence that is currently holding the world in a steady grip. Far from being inherently incompatible with liberalism, nationalism in moderate doses within fixed borders can help stabilize the conditions of representative democracy and ethnic inclusion. But in its radical and intolerant forms—especially when it interacts with imperialism—nationalism favors ethnic exclusion by targeting minorities and blocking inclusive compromises and concessions, such as power sharing and group rights.<sup>178</sup> In addition, as international efforts such as peacekeeping and international mediation weaken, liberal backsliding also increases the risk of conflict.<sup>179</sup>

A further rise of nationalist and populist strongmen around the world threatens to make the world safe for nationalist geopolitics. If our analysis is correct, current trends will likely continue—existing disputes will persist and numerous new conflicts will erupt within and between states. Such conflicts threaten to metastasize into larger clusters of regional instability and violence.

These projections suggest that it is all the more important to resist nationalist domination and to defend inclusive practices and institutions. Conversely, abandoning the LIO altogether in

response to the failures of liberal interventionism would be misguided, since the evidence indicates that inclusive institutions and policies are strongly associated with lower levels of conflict. If the decline in violence during the early post–Cold War period coincided with greater inclusiveness, then renewing and expanding such efforts today offers one of the most promising paths toward restoring peace and geopolitical stability.

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1. See, for example: Steven Pinker, *The Better Angels of Our Nature: Why Violence Has Declined* (New York: Viking, 2011); Joshua S. Goldstein, *Winning the War on War: The Decline of Armed Conflict Worldwide* (New York: Penguin, 2011).

2. Walter Russell Mead, “The Return of Geopolitics: The Revenge of the Revisionist Powers,” *Foreign Affairs*, Vol. 93, No. 3 (2014), pp. 69–79,

<https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/china/2014-04-17/return-geopolitics>; John J.

Mearsheimer, “Why the Ukraine Crisis Is the West’s Fault: The Liberal Delusions That Provoked Putin,” *Foreign Affairs*, Vol. 93, No. 5 (2014), pp. 77–89,

<https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/russia-fsu/2014-08-18/why-ukraine-crisis-west-s-fault>;

John J. Mearsheimer, *The Great Delusion: Liberal Dreams and International Realities* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2018).

3. Some scholars define geopolitics as the study of geographic determinism in world affairs, but we join most other scholar in using it in a wider sense to capture border change and conflict undermining the peaceful, liberal world order. See: Charles S. Maier, *Once Within Borders: Territories of Power, Wealth, and Belonging Since 1500* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2016); Carsten Nickel, “What Do We Talk About When We Talk About the ‘Return’ of

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<https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iia295>.

4. See, for example: Mead, “The Return of Geopolitics”; Monica Duffy Toft, “The Return of Spheres of Influence: Will Negotiations over Ukraine Be a New Yalta Conference That Carves Up the World?,” *Foreign Affairs*, March 13, 2025, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/united-states/return-spheres-influence>.

5. Dani Rodrik, *The Globalization Paradox: Democracy and the Future of the World Economy* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2011).

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7. Dominant nationalism is an ideology that demands that a specific ethnonationalist group controls state power and subordinates other groups within the state. See Andreas Juon and Lars-Erik Cederman, “Dominant Nationalism and Civil War,” *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, forthcoming. Other research refers to this phenomenon as “majority nationalism.” See: Lenka

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9. Gilpin, Robert. *War and Change in World Politics*. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1981).
10. We refer to alien or foreign rule as when an ethnic population is excluded from government and ruled by another ethnic group (i.e., not ruled by co-ethnics). For a general conceptual discussion, see Michael Hechter, *Alien Rule* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013).
11. We do not imply that all, or even a majority, of Russian speakers in Ukraine support the rebellion or the Russian invasion. To explain conflict, what matters is to identify the actors who resort to violence.
12. Manuel Vogt et al., “Integrating Data on Ethnicity, Geography, and Conflict: The Ethnic Power Relations Data Set Family,” *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, Vol. 59, No. 7 (2015), pp. 1327–1342, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/24546342>.
13. Francis Fukuyama, *The End of History and the Last Man* (New York: Free Press, 1992).
14. See, for example: Kenichi Ohmae, *The Borderless World: Power and Strategy in the Interlinked Economy* (New York: Harper Business, 1990); David Held, *Democracy and the Global Order: From the Modern State to Cosmopolitan Governance* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 1995); Ulrich Beck, *What Is Globalization?* (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2000).
15. Pinker, *The Better Angels of Our Nature*; Goldstein, *Winning the War on War*.



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16. Robert Kagan, *The Return of History and the End of Dreams* (New York: Vintage Books, 2009).
17. Ibid., p. 12.
18. Ibid., p. 23.
19. Mead, “The Return of Geopolitics.”
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21. Mearsheimer, *The Great Delusion*. For a similar critique of U.S. foreign policy along realist lines, see Stephen M. Walt, *The Hell of Good Intentions: America’s Foreign Policy Elite and the Decline of U.S. Primacy* (New York: Farrar, Straus, and Giroux, 2018).
22. Mearsheimer, “Why the Ukraine Crisis Is the West’s Fault”; Mearsheimer, *The Great Delusion*; John J. Mearsheimer, “The Causes and Consequences of the Ukraine War,” *Horizons*, No. 21 (Summer 2022), pp. 12–27, <https://cirsd.org/horizon-article/the-causes-and-consequences-of-the-ukraine-war/>.
23. G. John Ikenberry, “The Illusion of Geopolitics: The Enduring Power of the Liberal Order,” *Foreign Affairs*, Vol. 93, No. 3 (May/June 2014), pp. 80–90, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/china/2014-04-17/illusion-geopolitics>.
24. G. John Ikenberry, “The End of Liberal International Order?,” *International Affairs*, Vol. 94, No. 1 (2018), pp. 7–23, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iix241>.
25. See, for example: David A. Lake, Lisa L. Martin, and Thomas Risse, “Challenges to the Liberal Order: Reflections on *International Organization*,” *International Organization*, Vol. 75, No. 2 (2021), pp. 225–257, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0020818320000636>; Beth A. Simmons and Hein E. Goemans, “Built on Borders: Tensions with the Institution Liberalism (Thought It) Left

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Behind,” *International Organization*, Vol. 75, No. 2 (2021), pp. 387–410,

<https://doi.org/10.1017/s0020818320000600>.

26. John J. Mearsheimer, “War and International Politics,” *International Security*, Vol. 49, No. 4 (Spring 2025), pp. 7–36, [https://doi.org/10.1162/isec\\_a\\_00507](https://doi.org/10.1162/isec_a_00507). Mearsheimer argues that liberal theories “ignore or misconstrue the military variables” central to great power politics and that the fighting in “the Middle East and Ukraine” has cast doubt on liberal optimism about international politics; see pp. 8, 20. For his earlier critique of liberal hegemony, see Mearsheimer, *The Great Delusion*.

27. See, for example: Haggard and Kaufman, *Backsliding*; Carl Henrik Knutsen et al., “Conceptual and Measurement Issues in Assessing Democratic Backsliding,” *PS: Political Science & Politics*, Vol. 57, No. 2 (2024), pp. 162–177, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S104909652300077X>; Levitsky and Way, “The Resilience of Democracy’s Third Wave”; David Waldner and Ellen Lust, “Unwelcome Change: Coming to Terms with Democratic Backsliding,” *Annual Review of Political Science*, Vol. 21 (2018), pp. 93–113, <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-polisci-050517-114628>; Lührmann and Lindberg, “A Third Wave of Autocratization”; Stokes, *The Backsliders*.

28. See, for example: Christina Cottiero et al., “Illiberal Regimes and International Organizations,” *Review of International Organizations*, Vol. 20 (June 2025), pp. 231–259, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11558-024-09556-1>; Marlies Glasius, Jelmer Schalk, and Meta De Lange, “Illiberal Norm Diffusion: How Do Governments Learn to Restrict Nongovernmental Organizations?,” *International Studies Quarterly*, Vol. 64, No. 2 (June 2020), pp. 453–468, <https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/sqaa019>.

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29. There is, however, evidence that democratization causes civil or interstate conflict. See: Edward D. Mansfield and Jack Snyder, “Democratization and the Danger of War,” *International Security*, Vol. 20, No. 1 (Summer 1995), pp. 5–38, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539213>; Edward D. Mansfield and Jack Snyder, *Electing to Fight: Why Emerging Democracies Go to War* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2005); Jack Snyder, *From Voting to Violence: Democratization and Nationalist Conflict* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2000).
30. In this article, we focus on ethnic nationalism, which assumes that the nation is based on an ethnic group.
31. Ernest Gellner, *Nations and Nationalism* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1983), p. 1.
32. See Rogers Brubaker, “Populism and Nationalism,” *Nations and Nationalism*, Vol. 26, No. 1 (2020), pp. 44–66, <https://doi.org/10.1111/nana.12522>. We understand populism to be a moralistic way of framing politics by pitting a virtuous people against evil elites. See Jan-Werner Müller, *What Is Populism?* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2016).
33. Following World War I, liberal leaders introduced international norms and institutions that were designed to curb conflict. See: Oona A. Hathaway and Scott J. Shapiro, *The Internationalists: How a Radical Plan to Outlaw War Remade the World* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 2017); G. John Ikenberry, *A World Safe for Democracy: Liberal Internationalism and the Crises of Global Order* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2020). Whereas the first attempt to do so through the League of Nations failed, the post–World War II order featured a more robust effort to “contain nationalism.” See Michael Hechter, *Containing Nationalism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000). See also: Mark W. Zacher, “The Territorial Integrity Norm: International Boundaries and the Use of Force,” *International Organization*, Vol. 55, No. 2 (2001), pp. 215–250, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3078631>; J. Samuel Barkin and Bruce

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34. Zacher, “The Territorial Integrity Norm.”
35. For evidence that the LIO suppressed ethnic exclusion and irredentism, see: Steven I. Wilkinson, “Conditionality, Consociationalism, and the European Union,” in Sid Noel, ed., *From Power Sharing to Democracy: Post-Conflict Institutions in Ethnically Divided Societies* (Montreal: McGill-Queen’s University Press, 2005), pp. 239–262; Lars-Erik Cederman, Kristian Skrede Gleditsch, and Julian Wucherpfennig, “The Diffusion of Inclusion: An Open-Polity Model of Ethnic Power Sharing,” *Comparative Political Studies*, Vol. 51, No. 10 (2018), pp. 1279–1313, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414017740602>.
36. See, for example: Joanne McEvoy and Brendan O’Leary, eds., *Power Sharing in Deeply Divided Places* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2013); Cederman, Gleditsch, and Wucherpfennig, “The Diffusion of Inclusion.”
37. Zacher, “The Territorial Integrity Norm”; Fazal and Griffiths, “Membership Has Its Privileges”; Hathaway and Shapiro, *The Internationalists*.
38. Ted Robert Gurr, “Ethnic Warfare on the Wane,” *Foreign Affairs*, Vol. 79, No. 3 (May/June 2000), pp. 52–64, <https://doi.org/10.2307/20049729>.
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Wucherpennig, “Predicting the Decline of Ethnic Conflict: Was Gurr Right and for the Right Reasons?,” *Journal of Peace Research*, Vol. 54, No. 2 (2017), pp. 262–274, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0022343316684191>.

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41. Stephen M. Saideman and R. William Ayres, *For Kin or Country: Xenophobia, Nationalism, and War* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2008); Harris Mylonas, “Balance of Power, System Polarity and Irredentism,” *Journal of Global Security Studies*, Vol. 10, No. 1 (2025), ogae037, <https://doi.org/10.1093/jogss/ogae037>; Lars-Erik Cederman et al., “Nationality Questions and War: How Ethnic Configurations Affect Conflict Within and Between States,” *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, Vol. 69, No. 9 (2025), pp. 1495–1523, <https://doi.org/10.1177/00220027241312624>.

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58. While primarily externally oriented, this discourse also casts China’s ethnic minorities as alien to an authentic Han-centered conception of the nation. See John M. Friend and Bradley A. Thayer, “The Rise of Han-Centrism and What It Means for International Politics,” *Studies in*



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<https://doi.org/10.1080/14678802.2019.1705067>.

60. Mukta S. Tamang, “Social Movements and Inclusive Peace in Nepal,” in Deepak Thapa and Alexander Ramsbotham, eds., *Two Steps Forward, One Step Back: The Nepal Peace Process* (Brussels: Conciliation Resources, 2017), pp. 97–106, <https://www.c-r.org/accord/nepal/social-movements-and-inclusive-peace-nepal>.

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62. Rebecca Adler-Nissen and Ayşe Zarakol, “Struggles for Recognition: The Liberal International Order and the Merger of Its Discontents,” *International Organization*, Vol. 75, No. 2 (2021), pp. 611–634, <https://doi.org/10.1017/s0020818320000454>.

63. This figure depicts the share of states whose governments adhere to a nationalist ideology to legitimize their rule. Data for this figure are based on V-Dem’s classification of state ideologies. See Michael Coppedge et al., *Varieties of Democracy Dataset—Version 10*, University of Gothenburg, 2020, <https://doi.org/10.23696/vdemds20>.

64. In fact, with population weighting, this value is as high as 30 percent. The increased influence of nationalists in some of the most populous and powerful states (e.g., China, India, Russia, and the United States) drives this outcome.

65. In the online appendix, we present systematic evidence that this link exists. Table A1 reports a group-level two-way fixed-effects regression with the Ethnic Power Relations (EPR) database’s indicator of group exclusion as the dependent variable and V-Dem’s country-level

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index of nationalist ideology as the key independent variable. The results show that the latter is positively associated with the former.

66. Lührmann and Lindberg, “A Third Wave of Autocratization”; Waldner and Lust, “Unwelcome Change.”

67. See, for example, Joshua Tschantret, “Democratic Breakdown and the Hidden Perils of the Democratic Peace,” *European Journal of International Relations*, Vol. 26, No. 4 (2020), pp. 1129–1155, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1354066120916525>.

68. Democracy requires a stable and uncontested popular unit, a *demos*, which is often defined in ethnic terms. See Robert A. Dahl, *Democracy and Its Critics* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1989).

69. Gurr, “Ethnic Warfare on the Wane.”

70. Roger D. Petersen, *Understanding Ethnic Violence: Fear, Hatred, and Resentment in Twentieth-Century Eastern Europe* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002); Roger D. Petersen, *Death, Dominance, and State-Building: The US in Iraq and the Future of American Military Intervention* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2024).

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72. Amos Tversky and Daniel Kahneman, “Judgment Under Uncertainty: Heuristics and Biases,” in Daniel Kahneman, Paul Slovic, and Amos Tversky, eds., *Judgment Under Uncertainty: Heuristics and Biases* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1982), pp. 3–22.

73. Cederman, Gleditsch, and Buhaug, *Inequality, Grievances, and Civil War*, chap. 4.

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74. Vogt et al. “Integrating Data on Ethnicity, Geography, and Conflict.” URL:

<https://icr.ethz.ch/data/epr/>.

75. Countries that excluded ethnic groups are: the Central African Republic (CAR), Chad, Comoros, Côte d’Ivoire, the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC), Ethiopia, Guinea, Kenya, Liberia, Mauritius, Niger, Nigeria, Sierra Leone, Togo, and Zambia.

76. For instance, in Afghanistan after the Taliban takeover, as well as in Cambodia, Indonesia and Pakistan.

77. Such cases include Bulgaria, Moldova, Montenegro, Romania, Slovakia and Ukraine.

78. Using the categories provided by the EPR database, we operationalize state-controlling kin as any ethnic group that rules alone or is the only senior partner in a governing coalition. We identify transborder ethnic kin using the EPR-TEK component dataset, which codes transborder ethnic connections between EPR groups in different countries. See Vogt et al., “Integrating Data on Ethnicity, Geography, and Conflict.” The EPR-TEK coding is based on nominal matching: groups with similar or identical names across borders are coded as transborder ethnic kin.

79. Siegfried Morkowitz, “Anti-Corruption Opposition Wins Slovakia Election,” *Politico*, February 29, 2020, <https://www.politico.eu/article/smer-suffers-huge-defeat-in-slovakia-election-exit-polls/>.

80. These territories include large regions in Croatia, Romania, Slovakia, and other neighboring countries that include significant Hungarian-speaking populations. See Kate Maltby, “Viktor Orbán’s Masterplan to Make Hungary Greater Again,” *New York Review*, June 3, 2020, <https://www.nybooks.com/online/2020/06/03/viktor-orbans-masterplan-to-make-hungary-greater-again/>.

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81. “Bulgarian Parties Approve Coalition Agreement, Cabinet,” *Euractiv*, November 7, 2014, updated January 8, 2015, <https://www.euractiv.com/section/elections/news/bulgarian-parties-approve-coalition-agreement-cabinet/>.
82. Ivo Kirilov Ivanov and Murat Önsöy, “From Integration to Assimilation and Forced Migration: An Evaluation of the Bulgarian Communist Party’s Turkish Minority Policy,” *Bilig*, No. 103 (2022), pp. 31–58, <https://doi.org/10.12995/bilig.10302>.
83. Nick Danforth, “Turkey’s New Maps Are Reclaiming the Ottoman Empire,” *Foreign Policy*, October 23, 2016, <https://foreignpolicy.com/2016/10/23/turkeys-religious-nationalists-want-ottoman-borders-iraq-erdogan/>.
84. These cases include Benin, the CAR, Côte d'Ivoire, Djibouti, the DRC, Gambia, Guinea, Kenya, Liberia, Mali, Mauritania, Namibia, Nigeria, Senegal, Somalia, South Africa, and Tanzania.
85. Taras Kuzio, “Rise and Fall of the Party of Regions Political Machine,” *Problems of Post-Communism*, Vol. 62, No. 3 (2015), pp. 174–186, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10758216.2015.1020127>.
86. Anatol Lieven, “An Afghan Tragedy: The Pashtuns, the Taliban and the State,” *Survival*, Vol. 63, No. 3 (2021), pp. 7–36, <https://doi.org/10.1080/00396338.2021.1930403>.
87. See figure A2 in the online appendix.
88. This figure draws on the Uppsala Conflict Data Program (UCDP) and Peace Research Institute Oslo (PRIO), UCDP/PRIO Armed Conflict Dataset, Version 24.1, 2024, <https://ucdp.uu.se/downloads/>. Nils Petter Gleditsch et al., “Armed Conflict 1946–2001: A New Dataset,” *Journal of Peace Research*, Vol. 39, No. 5 (2002), pp. 615–637, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0022343302039005007>; Shawn Davies et al., “Organized Violence

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1989–2023, and the Prevalence of Organized Crime Groups,” *Journal of Peace Research*, Vol. 61, No. 4 (2024), pp. 673–693, <https://doi.org/10.1177/00223433241262912>.

89. Gurr, “Ethnic Warfare on the Wane.” The emergence of newly independent states following decolonization arguably accounts for some of the increase of civil conflict during the Cold War. For instance, James Fearon and David Laitin show that new states tend to experience higher rates of civil war. See James D. Fearon and David D. Laitin, “Ethnicity, Insurgency, and Civil War,” *American Political Science Review*, Vol. 97, No. 1 (2003), pp. 75–90, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055403000534>.

90. Shawn Davies, Garoun Engström, Therése Pettersson, and Magnus Öberg, “Organized Violence 1989–2023, and the Prevalence of Organized Crime Groups,” *Journal of Peace Research*, Vol. 61, No. 4 (July 2024), pp. 673–693, <https://doi.org/10.1177/00223433241262912>. For the original dataset, see Gleditsch, Nils Petter, Peter Wallensteen, Mikael Eriksson, Margareta Sollenberg, and Håvard Strand. “Armed Conflict 1946-2001: A New Dataset.” *Journal of Peace Research* 39, no. 5 (2002): 615-37.

91. Our break-point test of the post–Cold War trend in ethnic civil conflict identifies 2018 as the estimated turning point, with a high level of statistical significance ( $p = 0.002$ ). Figure A9 in the online appendix shows the same pattern using conflict intensity (i.e., battle-related deaths) rather than the number of conflicts. The figure combines UCDP/ Armed Conflict Dataset (ACD) conflict data with EPR coding of ethnic conflicts and draws on UCDP battle-death data reported in Davies et al. Nonethnic civil conflicts have also increased, much of this increase stemming from conflicts involving the Islamic State, but battle-related deaths in nonethnic civil conflicts remain considerably lower than in ethnic civil conflicts. This comparison indicates that

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ethnic civil wars are not only more frequent in the recent upturn but also substantially more destructive.

92. Kuzio, “Rise and Fall of the Party of Regions Political Machine”; Dominique Arel and Jesse Driscoll, *Ukraine’s Unnamed War: Before the Russian Invasion of 2022* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2023).

93. Luke Coffey, “Taliban and the National Resistance Front of Afghanistan,” Arab News, June 22, 2024, <https://www.arabnews.com/node/2535521>.

94. Myron Weiner, “The Macedonian Syndrome: An Historical Model of International Relations and Political Development,” *World Politics*, Vol. 23, No. 4 (1971), pp. 665–683, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2009855>.

95. See, for example: Donald L. Horowitz, “Irredentas and Secessions: Adjacent Phenomena, Neglected Connections,” in Naomi Chazan, ed., *Irredentism and International Politics* (Boulder, CO: Lynne Rienner, 1991), pp. 9–22; Cederman, Gleditsch, and Buhaug, *Inequality, Grievances, and Civil War*, chap. 6.

96. See, for example: Nadav G. Shelef, “Unequal Ground: Homelands and Conflict,” *International Organization*, Vol. 70, No. 1 (2016), pp. 33–63, <https://doi.org/10.1017/s0020818315000193>; Saideman and Ayres, *For Kin or Country*. It is thus possible that the increasing likelihood of irredentism at least partly explains the growing risk of ethnic civil conflict documented in figure A6.

97. Alex J. Bellamy, “Internationalized Civil War,” in Artur Gruszczak and Sebastian Kaempf, eds., *Routledge Handbook of the Future of Warfare* (London: Routledge, 2023), pp. 389–399.

98. Belgin San-Akca, *States in Disguise: Causes of State Support for Rebel Groups* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2016).

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99. Serhii Plokhyy, *The Russo-Ukrainian War: The Return of History* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2023).

100. Our analysis of interstate and internationalized conflict trends, reported in figure A7 in the online appendix, relies on the UCDP/PRIO Armed Conflict Dataset, Version 24.1. See UCDP/PRIO ACD, Version 24.1, 2024, <https://ucdp.uu.se/downloads/>; Therése Pettersson, UCDP/PRIO ACD Codebook, Version 24.1, UCDP and PRIO, 2024, [https://ucdp.uu.se/downloads/replication\\_data/2024\\_ucdp-prio-acd-241.pdf](https://ucdp.uu.se/downloads/replication_data/2024_ucdp-prio-acd-241.pdf).

101. Gurr, “Ethnic Warfare on the Wane”; Petersen, *Understanding Ethnic Violence*; Cederman, Gleditsch, and Buhaug, *Inequality, Grievances, and Civil War*. The initial studies using the Minorities at Risk (MAR) and EPR databases were based entirely on observational data and simple research designs, see Minorities at Risk Project, “Minorities at Risk Dataset,” Center for International Development and Conflict Management, University of Maryland, College Park, 2009, <http://www.mar.umd.edu/>, accessed July 7, 2026. Recent research that relies on more sophisticated causal inference, such as instrumental-variable analysis or structural estimation, confirms the validity of the exclusion-conflict link. See Julian Wucherpfennig, Philipp Hunziker, and Lars-Erik Cederman, “Who Inherits the State? Colonial Rule and Postcolonial Conflict,” *American Journal of Political Science*, Vol. 60, No. 4 (2016), pp. 882–898, <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12236>.

102. Here we are again relying on the Ethnic Power Relations dataset, see Vogt et al.

“Integrating Data on Ethnicity, Geography, and Conflict.” URL:

<https://icr.ethz.ch/data/epr/>. In a difference-in-differences estimation, we refer to the average treatment effect, assuming the treatment corresponds to a group’s downgrading.

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103. The approach is therefore well suited for observational data where random assignment to treatment and control groups is impossible. See Joshua D. Angrist and Jörn-Steffen Pischke, *Mostly Harmless Econometrics: An Empiricist's Companion* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2009). The online appendix discusses possible challenges to the identification assumptions and shows that concerns about anticipation and reverse causation do not generally compromise our results.

104. In the online appendix, we present the full regression results in figure A11 and table A2. We corrected cases in which the downgrade occurs in the same year as the onset of the conflict but before the actual conflict starts. Because EPR measures political status as of January 1 each year, the downgrade is coded in the year following the conflict, this rule [CLARIFY WHAT RULE] implies the wrong sequence (see more details in the online appendix).

105. Mykhailo Hrushevsky, “The Traditional Scheme of ‘Russian’ History and the Problem of a Rational Organization of the History of the East Slavs,” in *Stat'i po slavianovedeniiu*, Vol. 1 (St. Petersburg: Imperial Academy of Sciences, 1904), pp. 298–304. See also Georgiy Kasianov, “The War over Ukrainian Identity: Nationalism, Russian Imperialism, and the Quest to Define Ukraine’s History,” *Foreign Affairs*, May 4, 2022, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/ukraine/2022-05-04/war-over-ukrainian-identity>; Eugene Finkel, *Intent to Destroy: Russia's Two-Hundred-Year Quest to Dominate Ukraine* (New York: Basic Books, 2024).

106. Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, p. 10.

107. Ibid., p. 178.

108. Ibid., p. 170.



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109. Ibid.; Eleonora Narvselius, “The ‘Bandera Debate’: The Contentious Legacy of World War II and Liberalization of Collective Memory in Western Ukraine,” *Canadian Slavonic Papers / Revue Canadienne des Slavistes*, Vol. 54, No. 3/4 (2012), pp. 469–490, <https://doi.org/10.1080/00085006.2012.11092718>; David R. Marples, “Stepan Bandera: The Resurrection of a Ukrainian National Hero,” *Europe-Asia Studies*, Vol. 58, No. 4 (2006), pp. 555–566, <https://doi.org/10.1080/09668130600652118>.
110. Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, p. 181.
111. Ibid., p. 185.
112. Vyacheslav Likhachev, “The ‘Right Sector’ and Others: The Behavior and Role of Radical Nationalists in the Ukrainian Political Crisis of Late 2013–Early 2014,” *Communist and Post-Communist Studies*, Vol. 48, No. 2/3 (2015), pp. 257–271, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.postcomstud.2015.07.003>.
113. Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, p. 186.
114. Likhachev, “The ‘Right Sector’ and Others.”
115. Ibid.; Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, p. 189.
116. Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*; Kuzio, “Rise and Fall of the Party of Regions Political Machine.”
117. Arel and Driscoll, *Ukraine’s Unnamed War*, p. 1.
118. Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*.
119. Likhachev, “The ‘Right Sector’ and Others.”
120. Ibid.; Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, p. 190.
121. Likhachev, “The ‘Right Sector’ and Others”; Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, p. 191.

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122. Fiona Hill and Angela Stent, “The World Putin Wants: How Distortions About the Past Feed Delusions About the Future,” *Foreign Affairs*, Vol. 101, No. 5 (September/October 2022), <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/russian-federation/world-putin-wants-fiona-hill-angela-stent>.
123. Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, p. 164.
124. Ibid., p. 165.
125. Arel and Driscoll, *Ukraine’s Unnamed War*, p. 146.
126. Kuzio, “Rise and Fall of the Party of Regions Political Machine.”
127. Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, p. 11.
128. See Hill and Stent, “The World Putin Wants”; Kolstø and Blakkisrud, *The New Russian Nationalism*.
129. Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, p. 187.
130. Ibid., p. 11; Hill and Stent, “The World Putin Wants”.
131. Arel and Driscoll, *Ukraine’s Unnamed War*, pp. 1–3.
132. Thomas Barfield, “Afghanistan’s Ethnic Puzzle: Decentralizing Power Before the U.S. Withdrawal,” *Foreign Affairs*, Vol. 90, No. 5 (September/October 2011), pp. 54–65, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/afghanistan/2011-08-19/afghanistans-ethnic-puzzle>;  
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133. Coffey, “Taliban and the National Resistance Front of Afghanistan.”

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134. See Malkasian, “Is Afghanistan’s Long Civil War Really Over?”
135. Joshua Bowes, “Afghanistan’s National Resistance Front: Progression and Success,” Orion Policy Institute, October 14, 2024, <https://orionpolicy.org/afghanistans-national-resistance-front-progression-and-success/>.
136. Barfield, “Afghanistan’s Ethnic Puzzle”; Malkasian, “Is Afghanistan’s Long Civil War Really Over?”; Omarkhail, Guozhu, and Asap, “The Decline of Pashtuns.”
137. Barfield, “Afghanistan’s Ethnic Puzzle.”
138. Ibid.; Malkasian, “Is Afghanistan’s Long Civil War Really Over?”
139. Barfield, “Afghanistan’s Ethnic Puzzle,” p. 60.
140. Omarkhail, Guozhu, and Asap, “The Decline of Pashtuns.”
141. Barfield, “Afghanistan’s Ethnic Puzzle”; Malkasian, “Is Afghanistan’s Long Civil War Really Over?”
142. Omarkhail, Guozhu, and Asap, “The Decline of Pashtuns.”
143. See, for example: Rashid Ahmed, “The Taliban: Transformation from Pashtun Nationalism to Religious Nationalism,” *Pakistan Horizon*, Vol. 67, No. 2 (2014), pp. 83–100, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/44988688>; Salman Rafi Sheikh, “Pashtun Nationalism: Politics and Talibanization,” *Pakistan Horizon*, Vol. 69, No. 1 (2016), pp. 71–86, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/44988251>; Omarkhail, Guozhu, and Asap, “The Decline of Pashtuns.”
144. Sheikh, “Pashtun Nationalism.”
145. Omarkhail, Guozhu, and Asap, “The Decline of Pashtuns.”
146. Ibid.

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147. On the overwhelmingly Pashtun composition of the interim government, see: Barfield, “Afghanistan’s Ethnic Puzzle”; Omarkhail, Guozhu, and Asap, “The Decline of Pashtuns.”
148. Carlotta Gall and Adam Nossiter, “Budding Resistance to the Taliban Faces Long Odds,” *New York Times*, August 25, 2021; updated September 17, 2021, <https://www.nytimes.com/2021/08/25/world/asia/panjshir-valley-ahmad-massoud.html>.
149. Raja Qaiser Ahmed and Rafiullah Khan, “The Rise of Peripheral Nationalism in Pakistan and the Pashtun Tahafuz Movement,” *Asian Ethnicity*, Vol. 23, No. 2 (2022), pp. 215–229, <https://doi.org/10.1080/14631369.2020.1785840>.
150. Omarkhail, Guozhu, and Asap, “The Decline of Pashtuns.”
151. Elian Peltier and Zia ur-Rehman, “Pakistan Fights Its Fiercest Taliban Insurgency in a Decade,” *The New York Times*, October 6, 2025, <https://www.nytimes.com/2025/10/06/world/asia/pakistan-taliban.html>.
152. Figure A12 in the online appendix offers an event-study plot (see also model 1 in table A3).
153. See, for example: Hill and Stent, “The World Putin Wants”; Barry R. Posen, “Putin’s Preventive War: The 2022 Invasion of Ukraine,” *International Security*, Vol. 49, No. 3 (Winter 2024/25), pp. 7–49, [https://doi.org/10.1162/isec\\_a\\_00501](https://doi.org/10.1162/isec_a_00501); Mearsheimer, “The Causes and Consequences of the Ukraine War”; Katie Stallard, “What John Mearsheimer Gets Wrong About Ukraine: The Great-Power Realist Lets Theory Get in the Way of Fact,” *New Statesman*, October 5, 2023, <https://www.newstatesman.com/world/europe/2023/10/john-mearsheimers-incorrect-views-on-everything>.
154. Mearsheimer, “Why the Ukraine Crisis Is the West’s Fault”; Mearsheimer, *The Great Delusion*; Mearsheimer, “The Causes and Consequences of the Ukraine War”; Posen, “Putin’s Preventive War.”

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155. Additionally, these authors often do not explain why Ukraine wanted to join the North Atlantic Treaty Organization in the first place. Instead, they focus on the United States as the main actor driving this process. Moreover, they do not explain why Russia has not responded in the same way to Finland's and Sweden's accession to the defensive alliance, even though these countries are located near Russia and both possess a history of interstate disputes with Russia.

See Stallard, "What John Mearsheimer Gets Wrong"; Hill and Stent, "The World Putin Wants."

156. Eleanor Knott, "Existential Nationalism: Russia's War Against Ukraine," *Nations and Nationalism*, Vol. 29, No. 1 (2023), pp. 45–52, <https://doi.org/10.1111/nana.12878>; Hill and Stent, "The World Putin Wants."

157. Angela Stent, "The Putin Doctrine: A Move on Ukraine Has Always Been Part of the Plan," *Foreign Affairs*, January 27, 2022, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/ukraine/2022-01-27/putin-doctrine>.

158. Knott, "Existential Nationalism."

159. Pål Kolstø, "The Ethnification of Russian Nationalism," in Kolstø and Blakkisrud, pp. 18–45.

160. Hill and Stent, "The World Putin Wants." Further explanations of this conflict highlight Putin's own personal ambitions and his KGB background. See Fiona Hill and Clifford G. Gaddy, *Mr. Putin: Operative in the Kremlin* (Washington, DC: Brookings Institution Press, 2013). On what a democratic Ukraine might mean for Putin's autocratic rule, see Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, p. 10.

161. Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, pp. 8–9.

162. *Ibid.*, pp. 162–164.

163. *Ibid.*, pp. 10, 166.

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164. Odd Arne Westad, “The Cold War and America’s Delusion of Victory,” *New York Times*, August 28, 2017, <https://www.nytimes.com/2017/08/28/opinion/cold-war-american-soviet-victory.html>.

165. Finkel, *Intent to Destroy*, p. 11.

166. See, for example, Barry R. Posen, “Nationalism, the Mass Army, and Military Power,” *International Security*, Vol. 18, No. 2 (Fall 1993), pp. 80–124, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539098>.

167. Mearsheimer, *The Great Delusion*.

168. For instance, nationalism’s emergence in the nineteenth century destabilized the European state system, not least because of Germany’s unification and the weakening of the Habsburg Empire. See F. H. Hinsley, *Nationalism and the International System* (London: Hodder and Stoughton, 1973); Sir Lewis Namier, *Vanished Supremacies: Essays on European History, 1812–1918* (New York: Harper Torchbooks, 1963). More recently, Mearsheimer’s realist interpretation of the Russia-Ukraine War underestimates the extent to which nationalism can undermine not only liberal interventionism but also realist power projection. By treating Ukraine largely as an object of great power competition, this interpretation risks casting Ukrainians as pawns in a prenationalist era. See Mearsheimer, *The Great Delusion*. For more on how realism fails to fully acknowledge the power of nationalism, see: Lars-Erik Cederman, *Emergent Actors in World Politics: How States and Nations Develop and Dissolve* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1997); Lars-Erik Cederman et al., *Nationalism and the Transformation of the State: Border Change and Political Violence in the Modern World* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2025).

169. Such motivations can derive from ideological commitment or using narratives to boost popular resonance.

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170. Mearsheimer, *The Great Delusion*. For opposing evidence, see: Stent, “The Putin Doctrine”; Hill and Stent, “The World Putin Wants.” See also Posen’s interpretation of Putin’s invasion as a case of preventive war. Posen, “Putin’s Preventive War.”

171. Vladimir Putin, “On the Historical Unity of Russians and Ukrainians,” President of Russia, July 12, 2021, <http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/66181>, accessed July 7, 2026; Vladimir Putin, “Presidential Address to Federal Assembly,” President of Russia, February 21, 2023, <http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/70565>, accessed July 7, 2026. Putin’s dismissive answer to Tucker Carlson’s attempt to blame NATO expansion in a televised interview on February 8, 2024, further confirms this interpretation. See Vladimir Putin, interviewed by Tucker Carlson, “The Vladimir Putin Interview,” Tucker Carlson Network, February 8, 2024, <https://tuckercarlson.com/the-vladimir-putin-interview>; Tucker Carlson, “Ep. 73 The Vladimir Putin Interview,” X, February 8, 2024, <https://x.com/TuckerCarlson/status/1755734526678925682>.

172. Ironically, dominant nationalists are often as blind to reactive nationalism as most realists. For instance, Putin underestimated the Ukrainian nationalist reaction to Russia’s invasion of Ukraine in 2022.

173. See, for example, Posen, “Nationalism, the Mass Army, and Military Power.” Several prominent realist scholars, such as Mearsheimer and Stephen Van Evera, adopt sophisticated approaches to nationalism but tend either not to connect nationalism systematically to ethnic politics or to treat nationalism as a close relative of realism rather than as an integral component of realist theory. See Mearsheimer, *The Great Delusion*; John J. Mearsheimer, “Kissing Cousins: Nationalism and Realism,” paper presented at the Yale Workshop on International Relations, May 5, 2011,

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[https://www.sneps.net/t/images/Articles/11Mearsheimer\\_nationalism%20and%20realism.PDF](https://www.sneps.net/t/images/Articles/11Mearsheimer_nationalism%20and%20realism.PDF);

Stephen Van Evera, “Hypotheses on Nationalism and War,” *International Security*, Vol. 18, No. 4 (Spring 1994), pp. 5–39, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2539176>. See also Barry R. Posen, “The Security Dilemma and Ethnic Conflict,” in Michael E. Brown, ed., *Ethnic Conflict and International Security* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1993), pp. 103–124.

174. Ruggie, “International Regimes, Transactions, and Change.”

175. Several scholars call for “re-embedded” liberalism. See: Irfan Nooruddin and Nita Rudra, “Are Developing Countries Really Defying the Embedded Liberalism Compact?,” *World Politics*, Vol. 66, No. 4 (October 2014), pp. 603–640,

<https://doi.org/10.1017/S0043887114000203>; Edward D. Mansfield and Nita Rudra, “Embedded Liberalism in the Digital Era,” *International Organization*, Vol. 75, No. 2 (2021), pp. 558–585, <https://www.jstor.org/stable/27104649>; Broz, Frieden, and Weymouth, “Populism in Place.” See also Stefanie Walter, “The Backlash Against Globalization,” *Annual Review of Political Science*, Vol. 24 (2021), pp. 421–442, <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-polisci-041719-102405>.

176. Immanuel Kant, “Perpetual Peace: A Philosophical Sketch,” in *Kant: Political Writings*, ed. Hans Reiss, trans. H. B. Nisbet, 2nd ed. (1795; Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1991), pp. 93–130.

177. Simmons and Goemans, “Built on Borders.”

178. Again, we prefer to use the term dominant nationalism since this ideology is about status hierarchies rather than demography.

179. See, for example, Caroline Dunton, Marion Laurence, and Gino Vlavonou, “Pragmatic Peacekeeping in a Multipolar Era: Liberal Norms, Practices, and the Future of UN Peace



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Operations,” *Journal of Intervention and Statebuilding*, Vol. 17, No. 3 (2023), pp. 215–234,  
<https://doi.org/10.1080/17502977.2023.2217579>.